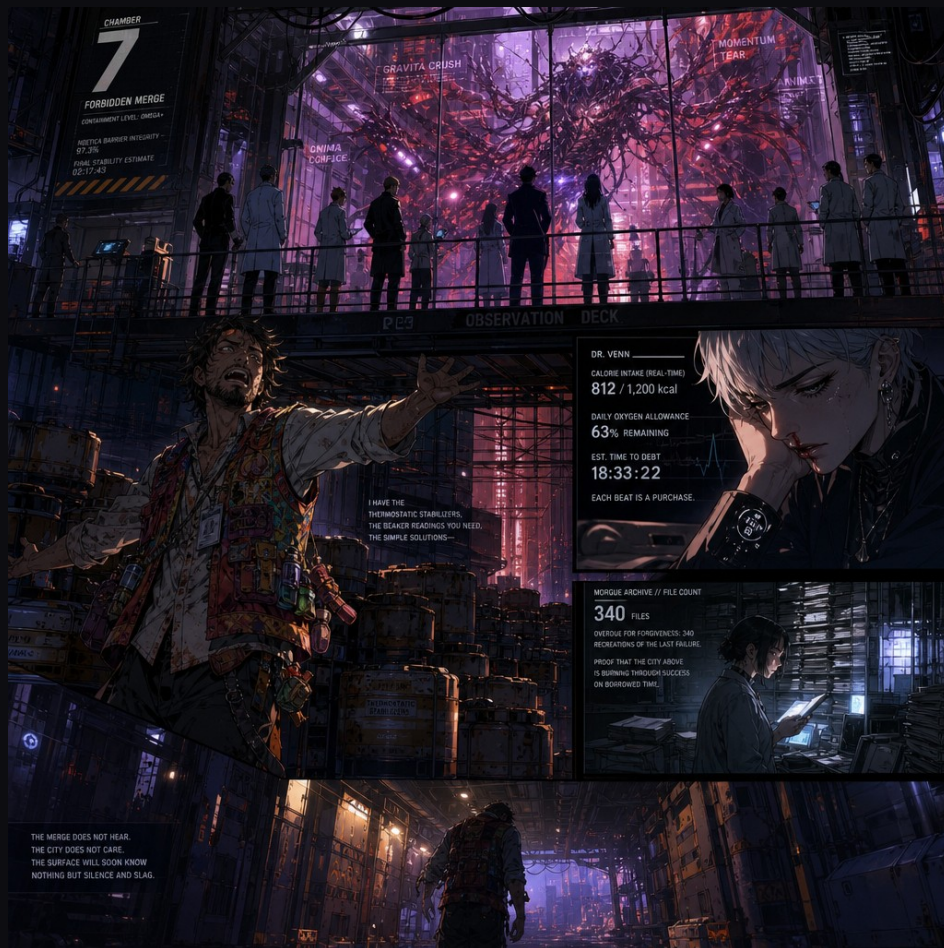
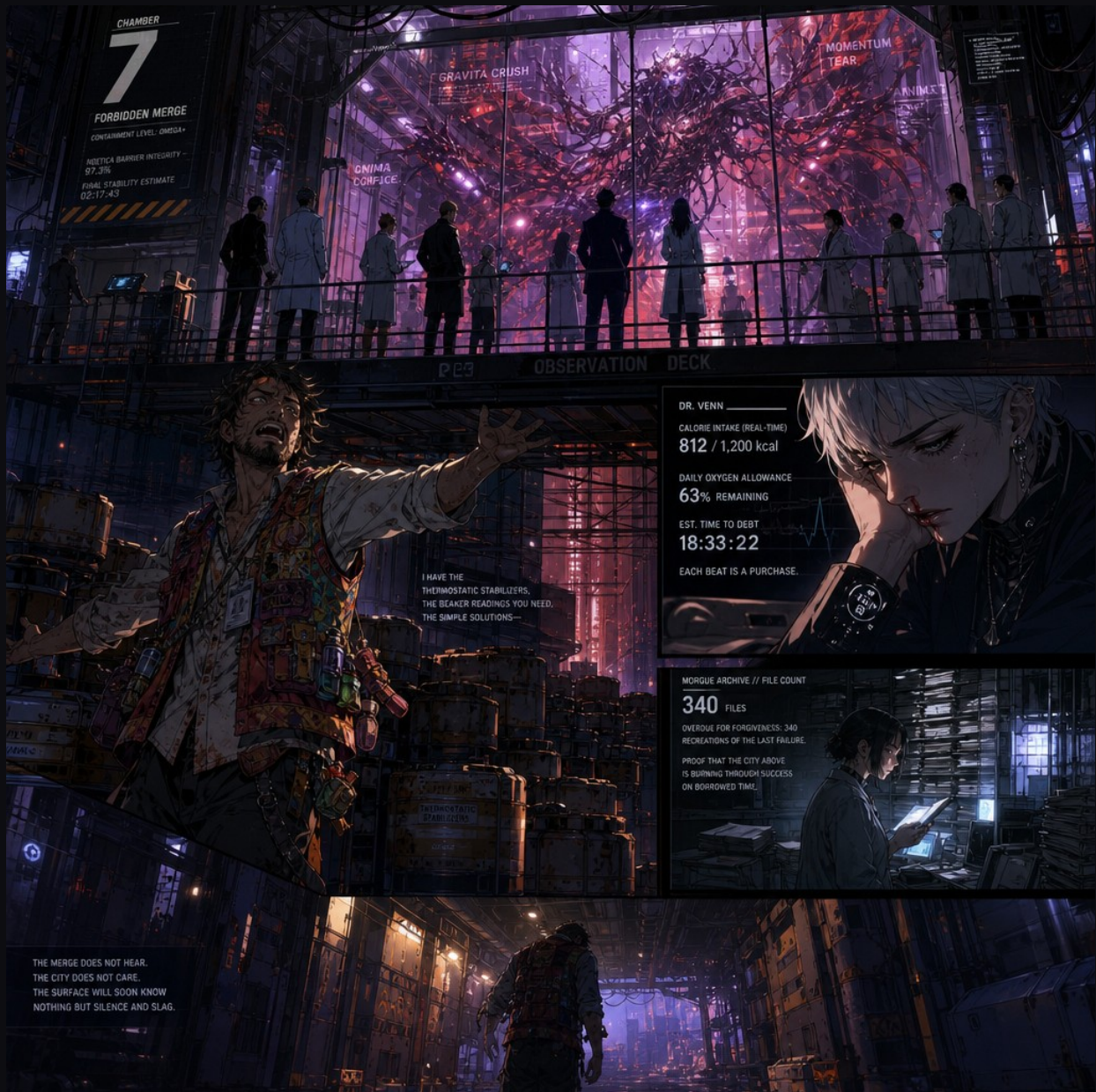




SG TAC

SERIES PRE S01

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Chamber 7 where the Forbidden Merge writhes in purple-and-crimson agony, flickering between Gravita crush and Momentum tear. His voice cracks: I have the thermostatic stabilizers, the beaker readings you need, the simple solutions - but the words disperse unheard into the hum of Noetica barriers, and his shoulders quake as though struck.



The Pinned Moon hangs motionless 380 kilometers overhead. A titanic celestial anchor wrapped in gravitational chains of crystallized Gravita.

Below, the crater's rim curves away like the lip of a wound that never healed. The permanent twilight zone stretches across 400 kilometers of shadow-lit landscape.

The Eclipse Spires rise from the edge—polished black ceramic and deep violet shadow, etched with UV-reactive fractals that resemble the veins of a sleeping organism.

They gleam with undeniable elegance while radiating a silent wrongness. As if the very stones remember what they cost to build.

Profunditas est Veritas. The absolute proof that truth, when built at this immense scale, becomes indistinguishable from catastrophe.



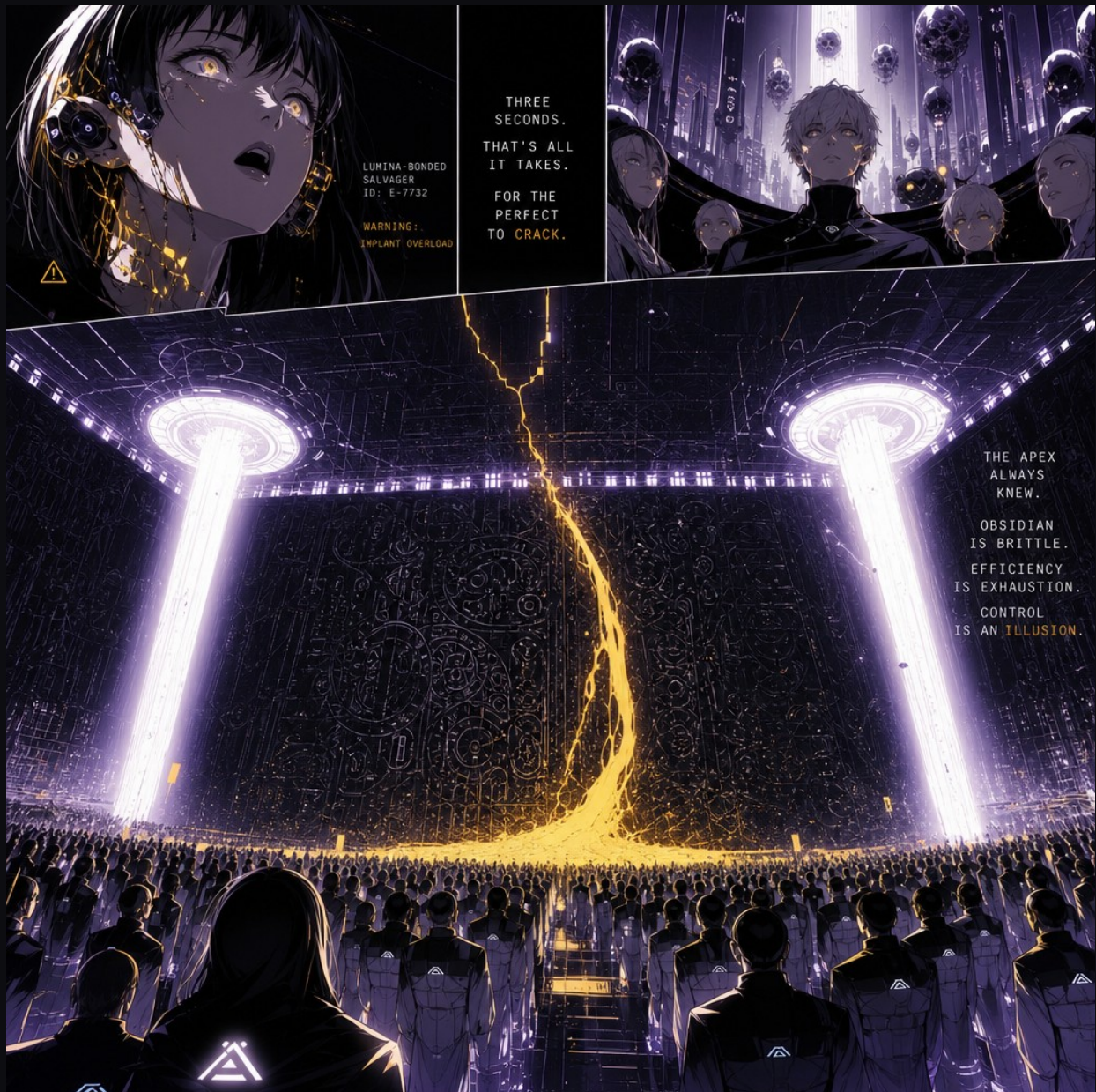
Two figures converge through Crater City's collapsing geometry. One descending from the Void's absolute darkness, the other ascending from the Deep's suffocating strata.

The Directorate representative walks over polished obsidian. Her shadow is a ghost-white inverse cast by Black Suns that no longer pulse in synchronized rhythm.

The salvager climbs through worn passages. Her wrist implant deducts calories for the light she's borrowed to seal a pressure valve that should have burst weeks ago.

Between them, the city's geometry betrays its architects. Relief patterns shift in peripheral vision. The governing Spectres no longer obey the regime's frequency.

When they meet at the civic threshold, the fractals on every wall glow a sickly, unauthorized violet. Not the clean geometry of control, but the color of something waking up.



Ten thousand voices synchronize in recitation. Their breath moves through the UV-Grid in perfect formation, a monument to the city's own discipline.

Then the obsidian seam splits. A hairline fracture weeps slag fluid downward in a thick, luminous ribbon, glowing sickly amber.

The crowd's synchronized breath catches. In that three-second window, every citizen witnesses the same inescapable truth: the city's perfect geometry is breaking.

A salvager gasps as her implant burns. She feels the Spectre's confusion ripple through her nervous system—a sensation like watching order collapse into static.

Three seconds is all it takes for the system to show its fractures.

No panic. No pause. Everyone continues...



Thirty meters below the observation platform, a merchant scrambles over supply canisters, hawking stabilizers to researchers whose backs remain turned.

Chamber 7 writhes in purple-and-crimson agony. A Forbidden Merge flickering between Gravita's crushing lens and Momentum's crimson tear.

Dr. Venn stands rigid at her ceramic desk. A silver nosebleed drips in sync with her wrist implant's calorie countdown—each heartbeat a theft of oxygen.

Two Anima locked in obscene conflict. Their opposing physics tear reality into fractured geometries, precipitating between states at blinding speed.

The merchant retreats into the honeycombed lower corridors. Carrying his worthless goods toward a surface soon to know only silence and slag.



Aboard the Velocity, Mira runs a maintenance check on her Hybrid Hoverbike. The Scrap-Dunes billow in rust-red undulation to every horizon below.

The bike is built from incompatible parts: Gravita, Momentum, Energia. It functions only through her relentless negotiation with their internal Anima.

She mutters an indefatigable rhythm of breath-work. Each exhale costs her calories as she mentally coaxes the impossible systems toward momentary peace.

Her consciousness is half-merged with the temperamental Spectres. She feels their dominant desire to fly pulling against her own stubborn, earth-bound refusal.



The grandmother's gasp. The father's footfall. A child's scream with no origin.
Inherited weight — not memory as thought, but as marrow.



Nova Terra crosses overhead: built, not born. A thing that chose to rise and took the sky to do it. The architecture defies baseline intuition. Buildings grow downward from the ceiling-floor, rooting into the sphere's interior surface. The air carries the heavy, unspoken weight of two hundred eighty years of biological divergence. High above and deep inside, children laugh in open configurations that would induce vertigo in surface-born minds.



The child stands alone on a translucent platform suspended above the Azure Drift Isles. His small frame silhouetted against water that shifts between liquid and light.

The air shimmers with silver-grey mist. A weight of attention so ancient it bends the light itself into faint concentric rings.

His breath leaves small clouds that resonate faintly with Noetica's silver radiance. His eyes track something moving through empty space with unselfconscious ease.

The water below reflects fractured moments layered like pages. Suggesting the entity's true form exists across time rather than space.

The mist stills. The entire island holds its breath, aware that something older than continents is learning the world through a four-year-old's voice.



In the resonant depths of the House of Echoes, three Hierarchs bend over Noel's transcription. Their milky-gold pupils tracking words that refuse to cohere.

Elder Kyr's weathered fingers trace the parchment. Silver mist coils from his temples—the mark of True-Sight burning at full intensity.

The child's words are not prophecy. They are testimony. Raw and unbidden, speaking of pressure-depths and singing that predates language itself.

Golden threads momentarily bind the Hierarchs. A shared recognition that this is not channeling, but partnership. The Trench Singer speaking through honest openness.

If this child is lost, the Singer moves blind. And the ocean remembers how to swallow cities whole.



The Surface Ring of Tidalcross erupts at the waterline. A vertical madness of salvaged hulls welded to coral-composite platforms.

A woman in pressure-marked skin climbs a maintenance ladder toward the sun. Each rung burns her adapted Deep Folk flesh.

Below, the ocean churns in rust-red foam where three currents collide. A Surface trader shouts numbers into a device, oblivious to the thousands of lives stacked without resolution.

300 meters down, Last Light Station registers a low-frequency pulse. A Fluidica presence waking in the geological deep.

Two incompatible worlds occupying the same space. The fracture is written in light, pressure, and the woman's burning skin.



The UV-reactive geometric fractals etched into the obsidian walls catalogue everything. They have been cataloguing for three hundred years. They do not distinguish between wounds.

Taro's hands hover. His Noetica pools silver-white at his fingertips, coaxing the tissue back toward itself. He has done this 730 times. Or 929. He stopped counting precisely when the counting became a kind of sleeplessness.

TARO (Internal): "Cellular memory negotiation. Standard contamination wound, sub-level presentation. Proceed with binding protocol seven."

But something has gone quiet inside him. The script that has sustained him for two years—the internal choreography of purpose—simply stops. Mid-word. Mid-gesture.

He walks toward the dark corridor where the Deep dwellers sleep. His red jacket catches no light. He is already becoming one more un luminous thing in this city of careful invisibility.



Taro's boots strike the polished obsidian floor in rhythm—each step a practiced whisper against the UV-reactive grooves that map Crater City's veins like luminous scars.

On his shoulder: Sparklefly. Her chaos-light flickers between crimson and ash-grey, casting differential shadows that refuse to settle. Neither of them speaks.

Sparklefly leans close to his ear. Her light sharpens into something singularly loyal. (Transmitted sensation): "The morn arrives whether we welcome it or not."

Taro says nothing. He keeps walking. Behind them, the upper levels' sterile efficiency fades into memory. Ahead: something ancient.



The screaming begins—not from speakers, but from the tar itself. Spirit Slag writhes beneath the UV grid with sickening, deep purple purpose.

Translucent, desperate hands claw upward from the roiling mass. Each one a fragment of a Spectre caught in an eternal loop of reconstitution and collapse.

The tar reaches toward the hero, yearning. The foundational truth of Crater City becomes inescapable.

The Tether burns cold in their chest. This is not industrial waste. It is suffering made structural, and a monument to systematic erasure.



He emerges from the thermal lock into absolute geometric clarity. No shadow play. Just the gravest cold and the moon overhead—pinned.

The Eclipse Spires: four obsidian needles, each one piercing the lunar disk from below, each one thrumming with a daemoniacal song that reverberates through the city's lowest chambers.

He looks up at the moon. He understands. Not in thought. In instinct. Like recognizing a hunger he's always carried—one he mistook for his own. The moon does not want to stay.

Every Crater citizen draws breath only because thousands of Gravita-Bound operators stand in absolute vigilance, their life-force leaking upward as an invisible tithe paid to the sky.

He has spent his entire life inside the moon's shadow without ever knowing he was underground.



Crystal-vine landscape. Porcelain-smooth glass-vines releasing faint shortwave frequencies with each step. Kai moves through the groves alone. Watchful. Exile chosen and maintained.

He follows the spore-drift patterns into the Shatter Fields. There: Taro, sprawled across fractured obsidian. Above him: Sparklefly, screaming in ultraviolet distress loops.

Kai kneels. Contact: his gauntlet on Taro's wrist. Sensation cascades. Kai feels the venerable roots reaching *through* Taro's body, testing. Semi-transparent glass-vine tendrils threading toward his respiratory system.

The jungle is deciding whether he continues or shrinks into the soil. Kai's Vitalis bond flares gold at the temples. A crusader's objection, stoically offered.

For an impossibly taut moment: the jungle considers. Then—slowly, reluctantly—the vines recede from Taro's lungs.



Kai lifts him. The movement is mechanical in execution and something else entirely in intent. The servos hiss, straining against the weight.

The arm that cradles Taro's torso does not merely carry—it **holds**. There is a distinction. The exosuit knows it. Its hydraulics perform it.

No dialogue. No explanation demanded. Just the wordless architecture of someone choosing protection over protocol.

Sparklefly's frantic circles gradually slow. She recognizes the offset from cruelty and begins to understand that salvation sometimes arrives dressed in cold armor, knowingly indifferent to philosophy.



Twilight bleeds through recovering greenery. Kai kneels beside the collapsed healer, his mech suit servos whispering with each micro-adjustment.

A medical scanner projects a layered holographic anatomy above Taro's motionless form. Broadcasting the brutal arithmetic of surface survival.

Taro lies face-down at the stream's edge. His fingers still curled around the water he never finished drinking.

The Sparklefly orbits frantically overhead. Chaotic light patterns cycle through worried purples and golds—Anima begging logic to choose mercy.

Kai's jaw tightens behind reflecting glasses. A ruthless HUD quantifies the conflict between mission efficiency and the visceral pull of compassion.



The abandoned research station hunches amid strangling vines. Its walls overtaken by bioluminescent fungi blooming in electric blues and phosphorescent ambers.

Undergrowth pulses with mutated ferns and drifting spores. The forest floor is a living patchwork of human ambition turned feral.

Kai kneels over Taro, his methodical fingers wrapping bandages around gashes. His HUD flickers with vital readings.

Chipster projects a faint holographic inventory. Dwindling medical supplies and iodine ampoules spread across cracked foundation stone.

Kai's void aura suppresses the ambient Vitalis shimmer. The jungle's sentient glow dims respectfully, recognizing the healer's work requires stillness.



Twelve pale figures materialize from humid undergrowth in synchronous choreography. Albino skin luminous against verdant shadows.

Living robes woven from cooperative vines cling to their frames. Bioluminescent moss pulses emerald rhythms across their shoulders and hems.

At the circle's nucleus stands their leader. Her staff crowned with a bulbous symbiote throbbing in tempo with her congregation's breath.

Kai rises between this tightening formation and Taro. His mech suit servos lock with absolute mechanical hostility.

The clearing's diameter collapses. The practiced ritual nudges toward violence cloaked in sacrament.



Kai extracts sleek black boots from the smuggler's crate. Their heels house violet cores pulsing with stolen Gravita essence.

A purple distortion ripples outward in a perfect sphere. Leaf litter and shattered bark rise in defiance of planetary pull.

Kai launches vertically—a purple contrail burning upward through hundred-meter trunks. Below, twelve cultists freeze mid-ritual, their religious certainty fracturing into awe.

Reversing polarity mid-apex, gravity flips. Kai plummets downward with controlled acceleration, his arm hooking Taro's waist in a single grab.

Mech thrusters fire in staccato bursts. They weave a three-dimensional evasion pattern no ground-bound marksman can predict, blurring past the ancient canopy.



The laboratory exhales centuries of silence. Thirty meters of organic-metal architecture sagging beneath the weight of jungle reclamation.

Bioluminescent fungi carpet every horizontal surface in waves of teal and cerulean. The soft diffuse glow renders the space a drowned cathedral.

Kai sits slumped against a corroded bench. Gravity boots beside him still radiating heat-shimmer from overuse.

Taro kneels an arm's length away. His hands move slowly over his bruised torso, cataloging damage with mechanical precision.

Sparklefly rests atop an intact spectrometer. Its chaotic pulse reduced to a faint heartbeat rhythm. A neutral ground where mechanic and healer can finally collapse without fear.



A hollowed root cavity wrapped in phosphorescent vine-lattice. Kai sets Taro down against the root structure. Enter: Chipster, a damaged tech-spirit.

Chipster's broken circuits recognize Sparklefly's prismatic arrival like an old wound suddenly feeling alive. They spiral around each other, making the living walls shudder into gold and green blooms.

Taro surfaces toward consciousness, his red leather collar catching the flare-light. He stands motionless, assessing whether this stranger in armor is threat or salvage.

Between them: the unmistakable tension of two men who sense they orbit the same gravity but cannot yet name it. Their silence is more eloquent than any declaration.

Outside, the jungle holds its breath. A 300-meter shadow crosses the shelter's opening. For one stretched second, all four presences recognize they are being appraised by something far older.



Therma-Energia merge. No warning. No negotiation.

Sand becomes glass. Glass becomes slag. Three tribes become past tense.

One perfect, terrible second of silence — then the ozone wall arrives.

She guns her engines toward the aftermath. There will be salvage. There will be bodies to bury. In the Drift, this is Tuesday.



The Scrap-Dunes shimmer under an inconvenient cyclone of sideways time. Reality glitches in spiraling fractals. Databent sand resolves into ghost-outcomes that flicker and reject themselves.

Mira rides her hoverbike into the storm's edge alone. The Dragon Guide's presence swells around her consciousness: vast, languorously patient.

Then: A momentary flash. A face she doesn't yet know. Caught in amber light. Falling.

Mira's breath catches. She kills the throttle at camp perimeter. Composed outwardly, but her hands betray her.

The unsaid thing sits between Mira's ribs like a swallowed stone. The Dragon Guide maintains its patient silence. It knows the particular grammar of prophecy—that it requires no language, only time.



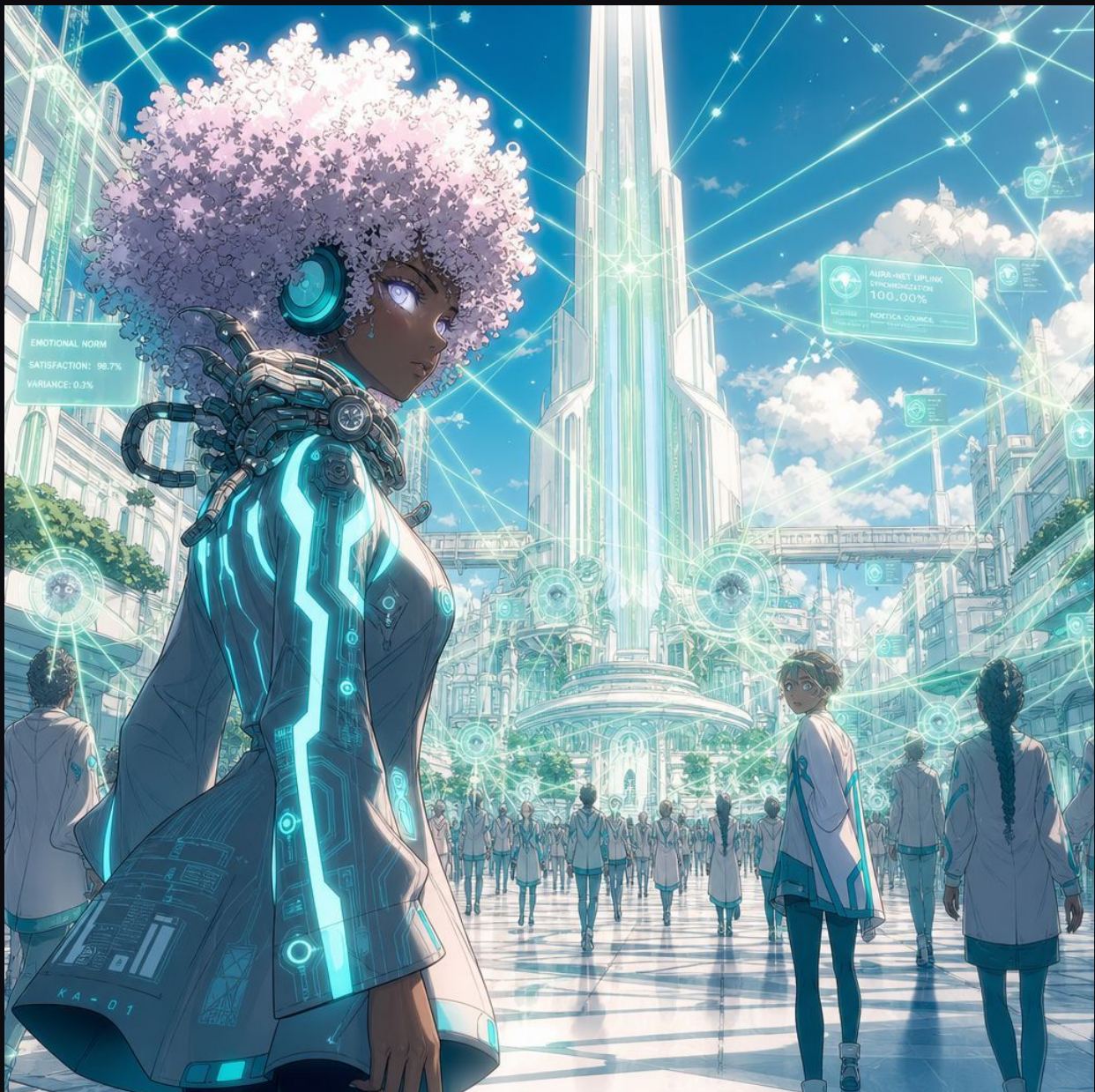
A vessel of non-local design enters the atmosphere over the open desert. It unfolds through geometry rather than descending—coherence-fold rather than trajectory.

Eve descends through alkaline haze. Her Lumina partnership effuses outward in powder-blue concentric rings that ripple across the glass-smooth dunes.

Overhead: Atairukh. The griffin traces methodical spirals, its wingbeats insidiously quiet, as if the creature reads the wind rather than moves through it.

Eve's boots touch the rust-red ground. Reality coherence stutters. The sand crystallizes briefly into lavender lattice—then settles back to grain.

In the scrap-haven, people mobilize in defensive formation. Eve watches them with the unmoved attention of someone who has arrived uninvited before. The opening move of a game whose rules the planet has yet to learn.



Nova Terra: blinding white and emerald. Shadowless architecture. Soft bloom lighting. A city that has not cast a shadow in three hundred years.

Kaori stands in the plaza's golden afternoon glow. Around her: the city's emotional broadcast arrives not as sound but as **feeling**. A millionfold wash of contentment-resignation.

Kaori's True-Sight ignites. Her eyes flash silver-white. The plaza transforms.

Invisible tendrils of Noetica snap into view—gossamer threads linking every iris to the central Celestia Spire, each beam pulsing with biometric data. The furtive spike of a second's doubt quickly smoothed away by the collective hum.

Horror. The Gearbit screeches, draining calories from her marrow. Her resistance broadcasts—just for a microsecond—as an unfrequent discord in the Aura-Net's symphony.

A figure three meters ahead pauses mid-step. Head tilting. They felt it. They felt **her**. The cheerfully ordered plaza develops its first genuine shadow in decades.



Lower Greenhouse Districts. Crystal-adapted ironwood. Flora that should be immune to rot, now bent into angles of dying grace.

Kael kneels at the grove's root base. Her hands press against the bark. She broadcasts forgiveness through the Vitalis partnership.

She does not know what she is doing. The contamination mimics natural disease so perfectly that her own healing magic becomes its vehicle. Each deepened negotiation widens the rot's pathway.

Silver-luminescent sap bleeds from fissures in the wood. Healing light—beautiful, ancient—flows from her palms into a wound that drinks it and sends it elsewhere.

This is wizardry weaponized not through conquest but through trust itself.



Rain-Maker: a sky-ship. Dew-Scribes sway in geometric precision, their voices braiding harmonic frequencies that coax moisture from the northland air into condensation nets.

Elara, blind and Vitalis-bonded, approaches the morning's first cup. She does not see the morning. She reads it. Pressure-waves. Salinity-whispers. The water's memory.

The copper vessel settles into her hands. It weighs wrong. Her kelp-consciousness partnership begins to broadcast alarm. The water tastes thin. Its memory insufficient.

As though something abyssward has begun to drain. The Dew-Scribes continue their song, unaware. Elara's grip tightens, listening to frequencies no one else can hear.



A cathedral of cold. 250 bodies suspended in the selfsame pose. The geometric precision of their arrangement suggests choreography rather than storage.

Kaori moves through the bay. Her True-Sight catches what instruments cannot: The Anima signatures are not silent. They are striated.

Each frozen form is inscribed with faint golden rings of Chrono energy, rippling outward in patterns that suggest not death but a ceremony of waiting, rigorously maintained.

250 suspended bodies, spinning together in some hothouse dimension. Kaori is weeping. The tears crystallize before they fall. These sleepers are not dreaming alone.

Her neural implant engages. Recording. The harmonic signature. What she witnessed here will dictate the arc of what comes next.



Nova Terra's market district. All organic curves and bioluminescent emerald glow. A city that has designed out conflict.

Taro enters, his momentum slightly too much. Kai is already present, armor cooling, servos straining against the pacifist geometry. Eve watches without appearing to watch.

Taro's elbow catches a cart of Gardenia blooms. The flowers scatter, releasing clouds of prismatic spore-light.

Kai's armor triggers stabilization. Hydraulic limbs reach with desperate precision, catching the falling blossoms before they impact. Preventing broadcast through the city's Aura-Net.

Eve's eyes flicker silver. As if she's already seen three versions of this moment and found them all equally meagre.

Three strangers, suspended in awkward simultaneity. Something unspoken passes between them. Acknowledgment of mutual inconvenience. The first note of something that will bind them beyond their consent.



Eve moves through the city's transparent corridors. Her seven Anima bonds run in mathematic synchrony. The city breathes around her in incandescent wellness.

Eve's attention catches what Nova Terra cannot categorically acknowledge: There are no shadows. At midafternoon, there are no shadows. No one here has learned to hide.

A thousand-year culture built on radical trust is a culture that has never been tested by betrayal.

Her seven spectres negotiate in sacred silence. Her stillness suggests she knows exactly what price this refulgence has cost the jungle below. She does not say this yet. She files it.



The Radiant District does not illuminate. It overburdens.

A Lumina architect, spent from the day's build — steadying herself against living bark, her Tether paid in full.

Behind her, two children who should not have come this deep. The younger one has stopped walking. Hands at her temples. Still.

Glare Sickness has no name for what it is — only a pressure the body indisputably fears before the mind can deduce the danger.



Kaori's fingers hover over a notebook-thin transmitter. The Aura-Net's golden warmth feels suffocating. The encrypted packet unfurls through invisible channels.

The tech-patterned strips on her jacket-dress flicker from cooperative gold to a deliberate, dangerous cyan that announces severance.

KAORI: "We launch forenoon tomorrow." Her voice is steady. Weighted with the irreversible. One final snapshot of the floating terraces before the Dim resistance pathway activates.

The Celestia Spire's detection algorithms begin their activation sequence. Something has changed in the symphony. Something is no longer singing along.



Crater City Mainframe. Kaelen. Not a man anymore. A computational nexus fused seamlessly into a throne of dark carbon and pulsing conduits. Amber eyes tracking seventeen simultaneous crisis points.

A healer abandoning his post. Spore contamination in the root-network. A blind woman holding a copper cup. A storm rider swallowing a vision.

Gold and silver rings ripple across his vision as temporal calculations branch and collapse. Each decision costing him. Sweating in anesthetic cold. Trembling.

He does not sleep. Does not hesitate. The apparatus does not permit these things. The apparatus requires absolute stillness. The apparatus is: Survival.



The Scrap Haven market canyon roars. Five faction leaders. Five irreconcilable positions. Beneath their feet: the Weldheart, its amber lattices flickering with vulnerability.

KORG: "We burrow or we perish. The dunes do not negotiate." JINX: "Stasis is blasphemy. Settlement is euthanasia."

Between them: Elara. Blind. Utterly present. Reading their breathing patterns. ELARA: "We do not choose anchor or motion. We choose which death we dignify."

The Weldheart's light dims. Not failure. Authenticity, at last, displacing notoriety.

The canyon breathes. All five faction leads breathing in unison. Shared mortality acknowledged. The silence is its own form of journalism.



A hollow ziggurat of buttressed root. The Keeper of Memory receives an unmarked data chip. She does not open it cerebrally. She holds it to her forehead.

She feels the data's weight. Four civilizations' fingerprints on contamination. Across all four cities—simultaneously. The same wound. Different architectures. One source.

Three days pass. She heals the afflicted. She walks the canopy bridges. The chip burns truthfully against her ribs.

By the third dawn, her hands shake. KEEPER: "There are fourteen days." The sentient forest thickens around her. It has understood for longer than she has.



Nova Terra. Lower platform edge. The translucent flooring is a skin barely holding back the knowledge of what lies below.

Taro sits first. Kai arrives in increments of mechanical necessity. Eve joins without announcing arrival, creating chromatic silence. Their shadows pool beneath them, compressing into unified darkness.

Thirty kilometers below: The Shadow-Scab. The wound is ancient. It radiates cold that has nothing to do with temperature: This is the ground that remembers being alive.

Sparklefly perches between them. Her internal luminescence withdrawn, fixed on the Scab below with an attention that reads as archaeological grief.

For the first time, the three of them share a synchronous thought they do not yet recognize they are sharing: Something is asking us to choose.

The city above broadcasts wellness through luminescent architecture. The city within broadcasts catastrophe through synchronized recognition. The wound below finally has witnesses willing to descend.

None of them speak. Language would only diminish what is being felt. But all of them know: The choice has already been made.